50 day trips every new Seattleite has to take

Sorted by vibe. From 30 minutes out to make-it-a-weekend.

Jeff Reynolds | Compass

Find your vibe

Saltwater vibe. Ferries, islands, harbor towns and the Sound

Lake vibe. Glacier-blue water from the Olympics to the dry side

Mountain vibe. Volcanoes, alpine lakes and the classic first hikes

Wine vibe. From 30 minutes in Woodinville to the far southeast corner

Small-town vibe. Main streets, old mining towns and a real city on the dry side

Wild coast vibe. Rainforest, sea stacks and the far edge of the map

Big sky vibe. Basalt canyons, Ice Age floods and the open dry side

- ● Easy day, 90 minutes or less
- ●● Full day, 90 minutes to 3 hours
- ●●● Make it a weekend, more than 3 hours

Drive times are approximate from downtown Seattle, no traffic, ferry included where noted.

Saltwater vibe

Ferries, islands, harbor towns and the Sound

01 Bainbridge Island • 35 min ferry

02 Vashon Island • ~45 min with ferry

03 Gig Harbor • ~1 hr

04 Poulsbo • ~1 hr with ferry

05 La Conner • ~1 hr 15 min

06 Deception Pass • ~1 hr 30 min

07 Port Townsend •• ~2 hrs with ferry

08 San Juan Islands •• ~1 hr 30 min + ferry

Closest launch points: West Seattle (Fauntleroy ferry); Downtown and Belltown (walk-on ferries at Colman Dock); Edmonds (Kingston ferry)

Bainbridge Island

Kitsap, via the Seattle ferry

- 35 min ferry

Walk on the ferry at Colman Dock, and 35 minutes later you are strolling Winslow with the skyline behind you.

Pass: Ferry fare

Best: Year-round

Saltwater vibe · 02

Vashon Island

Fauntleroy ferry, West Seattle

- ~45 min with ferry

Farm stands, quiet beaches and Point Robinson Lighthouse, one short crossing from West Seattle.

Pass: Ferry fare

Best: Year-round

Jeff's pick · 03

Gig Harbor

Pierce County, across the Narrows

• ~1 hr

A working harbor town with a fishing-fleet past. Walk Harborview Drive, then get on the water with Rainier in view on a clear day.

Pass: None

Best: Year-round

Where I grew up. Still my favorite harbor on the Sound.

Saltwater vibe · 04

Poulsbo

Liberty Bay, Kitsap

- ~1 hr with ferry

Little Norway on Liberty Bay: Scandinavian storefronts, a waterfront park and a boardwalk along the marina.

Pass: Ferry fare

Best: Year-round

La Conner

Skagit Valley

~1 hr 15 min

A small waterfront town on the Swinomish Channel. Time it for the Skagit tulips in April.

Pass: None

Best: Best in April

Deception Pass

Whidbey and Fidalgo Islands

- ~1 hr 30 min

The 1935 bridge hangs about 180 feet above a churning tidal current. Walk the span, then take the beach trails below.

Pass: Discover Pass

Best: Year-round

Port Townsend

Quimper Peninsula, via the Edmonds-Kingston ferry

●● ~2 hrs with ferry

A Victorian seaport at the tip of the peninsula. Spend the afternoon in the bunkers and on the beach at Fort Worden.

Pass: Discover Pass at Fort Worden

Best: Year-round

San Juan Islands

Ferry from Anacortes

●● ~1 hr 30 min + ferry

Ferry to Friday Harbor, then Lime Kiln Point for the lighthouse and, in summer, a shot at orcas from shore.

Pass: Ferry fare; Discover Pass at Lime Kiln

Best: Best May to September

Reserve your car spot on the ferry.

Lake vibe

Glacier-blue water from the Olympics to the dry side

09 Lake Wenatchee ●● ~2 hrs 15 min

10 Baker Lake ●● ~2 hrs 15 min

11 Lake Cushman ●● ~2 hrs 15 min

12 Lake Crescent ●● ~2 hrs 45 min with ferry

13 Soap Lake ●● ~2 hrs 45 min

14 Banks Lake ●● ~3 hrs

15 Lake Chelan ●●● ~3 hrs 15 min

Closest launch points: Eastside along I-90 and US 2; Downtown (Bainbridge ferry for the Olympic lakes)

Lake Wenatchee

US 2, past Leavenworth

●● ~2 hrs 15 min

A glacial lake at the foot of the Cascades with a sandy state-park beach, about 25 minutes past Leavenworth.

Pass: Discover Pass

Best: Best June to September

Lake vibe · 10

Baker Lake

Upper Skagit, under Mount Baker

●● ~2 hrs 15 min

A long, glacier-fed reservoir under Mount Baker, with lakeside trails through old-growth forest.

Pass: NW Forest Pass at some trailheads

Best: Best June to October

Lake Cushman

Hood Canal, southeast Olympics

●● ~2 hrs 15 min

Turquoise water in the southeast Olympics, with the Staircase trails at the far end of the gravel road.

Pass: National park fee at Staircase

Best: Best June to September

Lake Crescent

Olympic Peninsula, US 101

●● ~2 hrs 45 min with ferry

Glacially carved, famously clear and deep blue. Pair it with the short trail to Marymere Falls.

Pass: None on US 101

Best: Year-round

Soap Lake

Grand Coulee

●● ~2 hrs 45 min

A mineral-heavy lake people have soaked in for generations, minutes from Dry Falls.

Pass: None

Best: Best May to September

Lake vibe · 14

Banks Lake

Grand Coulee

●● ~3 hrs

A long reservoir between basalt canyon walls, with Steamboat Rock rising straight out of the water.

Pass: Discover Pass at Steamboat Rock

Best: Best May to October

Lake vibe · 15

Lake Chelan

North Central Washington

●●● ~3 hrs 15 min

A 50-mile glacial lake in dry, sunny country. Swim in town, then taste at the wineries on the hillsides.

Pass: None in town

Best: Best June to September

Mountain vibe

Volcanoes, alpine lakes and the classic first hikes

16 Snoqualmie Falls ● ~35 min

17 Rattlesnake Ledge ● ~45 min

18 Mount Rainier: Paradise ●● ~2 hrs 15 min

19 Mount Rainier: Sunrise ●● ~2 hrs 30 min

20 North Cascades: Diablo Lake ●● ~2 hrs 30 min

21 Colchuck Lake ●● ~2 hrs 30 min + rough road

22 Artist Point ●● ~2 hrs 45 min

23 Hurricane Ridge ●● ~2 hrs 45 min with ferry

24 Mount St. Helens ●● ~2 hrs 45 min

Closest launch points: Issaquah and the I-90 corridor; Eastside (Bellevue, Kirkland)

Mountain vibe · 16

Snoqualmie Falls

Snoqualmie

- ~35 min

A 268-foot waterfall 35 minutes from downtown. The overlook is steps from the parking lot.

Pass: Paid parking in the upper lot

Best: Year-round, biggest in spring



Rattlesnake Ledge

North Bend, I-90

• ~45 min

About 4 miles round trip to a rock ledge high above Rattlesnake Lake. The classic first Seattle hike.

Pass: None

Best: Year-round, go early on weekends

Mountain vibe · 18

Mount Rainier: Paradise

Mount Rainier National Park

●● ~2 hrs 15 min

Wildflower meadows in summer, snowshoes in winter, and the mountain filling the whole sky. Start with the Skyline Trail.

Pass: National park entry fee

Best: Year-round, wildflowers late July to August

No timed-entry reservation required in 2026.

Mount Rainier: Sunrise

Mount Rainier National Park

●● ~2 hrs 30 min

The highest point you can drive to in the park, with the mountain close enough to feel.

Pass: National park entry fee

Best: Summer only, seasonal road

Mountain vibe · 20

North Cascades: Diablo Lake

Highway 20

●● ~2 hrs 30 min

Glacial silt turns Diablo Lake an unreal turquoise. Stop at the vista point, then push on to Washington Pass if you have daylight.

Pass: None

Best: Spring to fall; Highway 20 closes for winter

Colchuck Lake

The Enchantments, near Leavenworth

●● ~2 hrs 30 min + rough road

8 miles round trip and about 2,300 feet up to glacier-blue water under Dragontail Peak. The realistic day-hike version of the Enchantments.

Pass: NW Forest Pass or $5 day fee; free day-use permit at the trailhead

Best: Summer to October; access road typically closed November to May

No dogs. The lot fills early.

Mountain vibe · 22

Artist Point

End of the Mount Baker Highway

●● ~2 hrs 45 min

Mount Baker and Mount Shuksan both in view from the end of the road.

Pass: NW Forest Pass

Best: Midsummer to fall, road snowbound the rest of the year

Hurricane Ridge

Olympic National Park, above Port Angeles

●● ~2 hrs 45 min with ferry

Drive from Port Angeles up to a ridge about a mile high, staring straight into the Olympics.

Pass: National park entry fee

Best: Best summer; winter access varies

Call the park road line (360-565-3131) before you go.

Mountain vibe · 24

Mount St. Helens

Spirit Lake Highway (SR 504)

●● ~2 hrs 45 min

The 1980 blast zone still reads like a geology textbook, with Coldwater Lake and the lower viewpoints along SR 504.

Pass: Varies by site

Best: Late spring to fall

Johnston Ridge Observatory is closed while SR 504 is rebuilt. Check access before you go.

Wine vibe

From 30 minutes in Woodinville to the far southeast corner

25 Woodinville ● ~30 min

26 Yakima Valley ●● ~2 hrs 30 min

27 Prosser ●● ~3 hrs

28 Red Mountain ●●● ~3 hrs 15 min

29 Maryhill and the Columbia Gorge ●●● ~3 hrs 45 min

30 Walla Walla ●●● ~4 hrs 15 min

Closest launch points: Woodinville, Kirkland and Bothell; Eastside along I-90

Wine vibe · 25

Woodinville

Eastside

- ~30 min

Over 100 tasting rooms 30 minutes from downtown. Wine country with no overnight required.

Pass: None

Best: Year-round

Yakima Valley

Central Washington

●● ~2 hrs 30 min

Washington's first wine region: wineries, hop fields and fruit stands stretched across the valley.

Pass: None

Best: Best May to October, harvest in fall



Wine vibe · 27

Prosser

Lower Yakima Valley

●● ~3 hrs

A small town packed with tasting rooms. The easy base for Yakima Valley wine.

Pass: None

Best: Year-round

Wine vibe · 28

Red Mountain

Benton City

●●● ~3 hrs 15 min

A tiny, sunbaked growing region above the Yakima River, known for big, bold reds.

Pass: None

Best: Year-round

Maryhill and the Columbia Gorge

Goldendale

●●● ~3 hrs 45 min

Wine on the cliffs above the Columbia, plus the Maryhill Museum of Art and a full-size Stonehenge replica built as a WWI memorial.

Pass: Museum admission

Best: Spring to fall

Wine vibe · 30

Walla Walla

Southeast Washington

●●● ~4 hrs 15 min

More than 100 wineries and a walkable downtown built for tasting-room hopping.

Pass: None

Best: Year-round, harvest in fall

Book a driver or stay the night.



Small-town vibe

Main streets, old mining towns and a real city on the dry side

31 Snohomish ● ~40 min

32 Roslyn and Cle Elum ● ~1 hr 30 min

33 Bellingham and Chuckanut Drive ● ~1 hr 30 min

34 Ellensburg ●● ~1 hr 45 min

35 Leavenworth ●● ~2 hrs 15 min

36 Winthrop ●●● ~3 hrs 30 min

37 Omak ●●● ~4 hrs

38 Spokane ●●● ~4 hrs 30 min

Closest launch points: North Seattle for I-5 north; Eastside for I-90 and US 2

Snohomish

Snohomish County

• ~40 min

Antique shops along First Street and a riverfront trail, 40 minutes north.

Pass: None

Best: Year-round

Roslyn and Cle Elum

Upper Kittitas County

- ~1 hr 30 min

Two old coal-mining towns a few miles apart in the Cascade foothills. Walk Roslyn's historic main street, then wander Cle Elum and the river trails nearby.

Pass: None

Best: Year-round



Bellingham and Chuckanut Drive

Whatcom County

• ~1 hr 30 min

Fairhaven's brick historic district, then Chuckanut Drive's cliffside views over Samish Bay.

Pass: None

Best: Year-round, sunsets best in summer

Small-town vibe · 34

Ellensburg

Kittitas Valley

●● ~1 hr 45 min

College-town cowboy country on the dry side, with a brick downtown and the Yakima River Canyon drive nearby.

Pass: None

Best: Year-round

Leavenworth

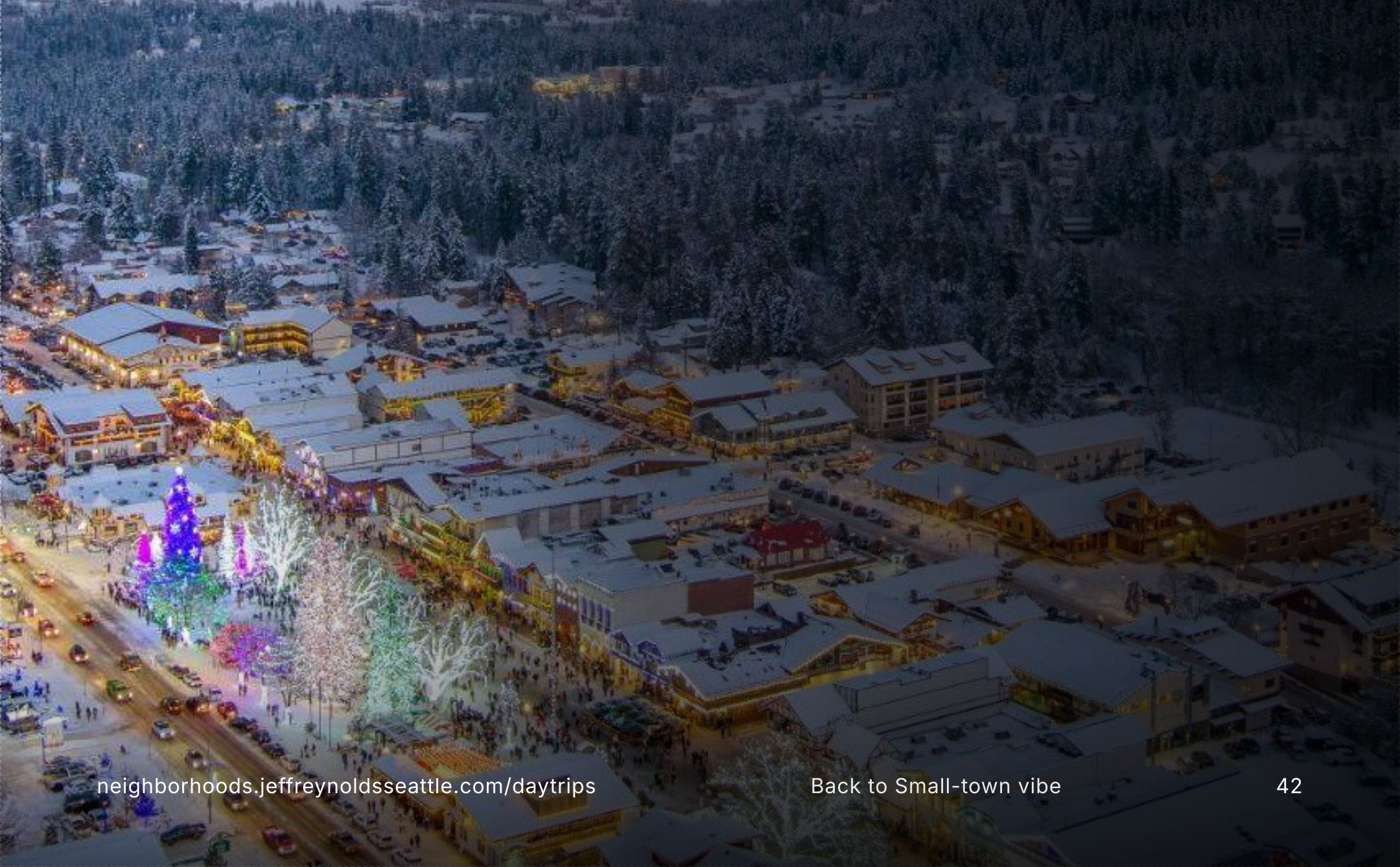
US 2, Chelan County

●● ~2 hrs 15 min

A Bavarian-style village tucked into the Cascades. Go midweek or in shoulder season to dodge the crowds.

Pass: None in town

Best: Year-round



Small-town vibe · 36

Winthrop

Methow Valley

●●● ~3 hrs 30 min

An Old West storefront town in the Methow Valley, reached over the North Cascades Highway.

Pass: None

Best: Spring to fall via Highway 20

Highway 20 closes in winter, which adds hours via US 2.

Omak

Okanogan County

●●● ~4 hrs

Okanogan ranch country. Time it for the Omak Stampede in August and it becomes a trip you will talk about for years.

Pass: Event tickets

Best: Stampede weekend in August

Small-town vibe · 38

Spokane

Eastern Washington

●●● ~4 hrs 30 min

A real city on the dry side, with Spokane Falls thundering through Riverfront Park right downtown.

Pass: None

Best: Year-round, falls biggest in spring

Wild coast vibe

Rainforest, sea stacks and the far edge of the map

39 Westport ●● ~2 hrs 15 min

40 Lake Quinault ●● ~3 hrs

41 Cape Disappointment ●●● ~3 hrs 15 min

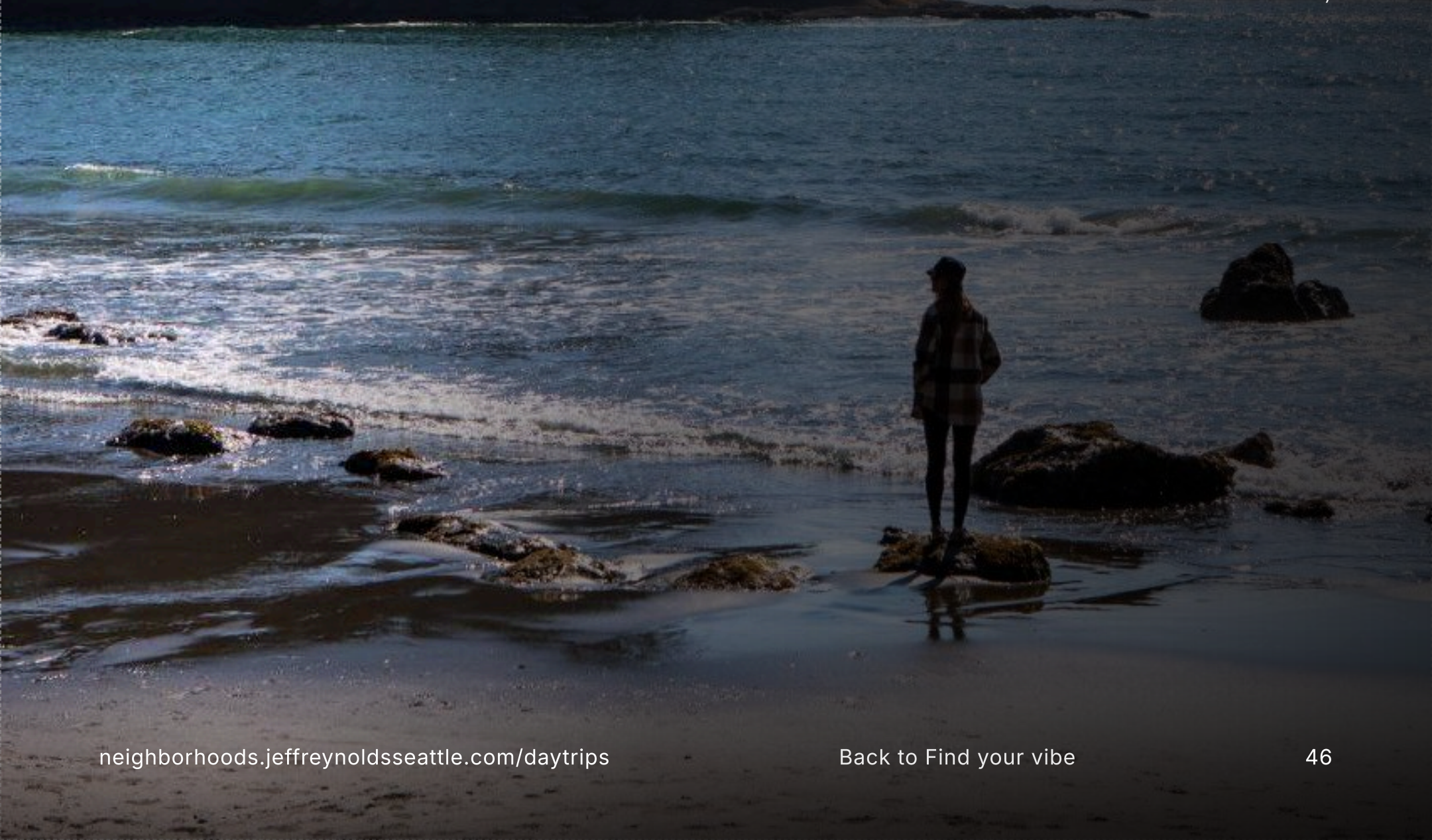
42 Hoh Rain Forest ●●● ~4 hrs

43 Rialto Beach ●●● ~4 hrs

44 Ruby Beach ●●● ~4 hrs 15 min

45 Cape Flattery ●●● ~4 hrs 30 min

Closest launch points: Downtown (Bainbridge ferry); West Seattle (Fauntleroy to Southworth)



Westport

Grays Harbor

●● ~2 hrs 15 min

A surf beach, a working fishing harbor and Grays Harbor Lighthouse, the tallest in the state.

Pass: None in town

Best: Year-round



Wild coast vibe · 40

Lake Quinault

Southwest Olympics

●● ~3 hrs

A rainforest lake ringed by old-growth giants, with an easy loop trail through the moss.

Pass: Varies by trailhead

Best: Year-round

Cape Disappointment

Long Beach Peninsula

●●● ~3 hrs 15 min

Two lighthouses where the Columbia River meets the Pacific, with the long sweep of the Long Beach Peninsula next door.

Pass: Discover Pass

Best: Year-round, storm watching in winter

Wild coast vibe · 42

Hoh Rain Forest

Olympic National Park

●●● ~4 hrs

12 to 14 feet of rain a year builds moss so thick it hushes everything. The Hall of Mosses loop is under a mile.

Pass: National park entry fee

Best: Year-round

Rialto Beach

Near La Push

●●● ~4 hrs

Sea stacks, giant drift logs and a beach walk north to Hole-in-the-Wall at low tide.

Pass: None

Best: Year-round; check the tide table

Wild coast vibe · 44

Ruby Beach

US 101, Olympic coast

●●● ~4 hrs 15 min

Reddish sand, sea stacks and tide pools, a short walk down from Highway 101.

Pass: None

Best: Year-round; go at low tide

Cape Flattery

Makah Reservation, Neah Bay

●●● ~4 hrs 30 min

The northwesternmost point of the contiguous U.S. A short boardwalk trail ends at cliffs, sea caves and Tatoosh Island.

Pass: $20 Makah Recreation Pass per vehicle, good for the calendar year

Best: Year-round

Respect tribal land and stay in visitor areas.

Big sky vibe

Basalt canyons, Ice Age floods and the open dry side

46 Vantage: Frenchman Coulee and Ginkgo ●● ~2 hrs 15 min

47 Dry Falls ●● ~3 hrs

48 Grand Coulee Dam ●●● ~3 hrs 30 min

49 Palouse Falls ●●● ~4 hrs

50 Steptoe Butte ●●● ~4 hrs 45 min

Closest launch points: Eastside along I-90

Vantage: Frenchman Coulee and Ginkgo

Columbia River, I-90

●● ~2 hrs 15 min

Basalt columns at Frenchman Coulee and petrified wood at Ginkgo Petrified Forest, both above the Columbia.

Pass: Discover Pass

Best: Best spring and fall

Dry Falls

Coulee City

●● ~3 hrs

A 3.5-mile-wide, 400-foot cliff carved by Ice Age floods, once a waterfall that dwarfed Niagara.

Pass: Discover Pass

Best: Spring to fall

Big sky vibe · 48

Grand Coulee Dam

Grand Coulee

●●● ~3 hrs 30 min

One of the largest concrete structures in North America. Summer nights bring a laser light show on the spillway.

Pass: None

Best: Best in summer

Palouse Falls

Palouse Falls State Park

●●● ~4 hrs

A 198-foot drop into a basalt bowl, and Washington's official state waterfall.

Pass: Discover Pass

Best: Biggest flow in spring

Pair with Walla Walla for a weekend.

Steptoe Butte

The Palouse

●●● ~4 hrs 45 min

A summit road above the rolling Palouse wheat hills. Go at golden hour.

Pass: Discover Pass

Best: Greenest in May and June, gold in late summer

Before you go

Discover Pass: $45 a year, covers state parks and most state land in this guide.

Northwest Forest Pass: needed at many national forest trailheads (Colchuck, Artist Point, some Baker Lake trailheads).

National park entry: Mount Rainier and Olympic charge a per-vehicle fee, or use an America the Beautiful annual pass.

Makah Recreation Pass: $20 per vehicle for Cape Flattery, good for the calendar year.

Ferries: reserve a car spot for the San Juans.

Seasonal roads: Highway 20, the Colchuck access road, Sunrise and Artist Point all close for winter.

Pick your vibe. I'll pick your neighborhood.

Where you live decides how often you actually go. Live near a ferry terminal and the islands become a Saturday habit. Live on the Eastside and the mountains are 40 minutes away. Tell me your vibe and I'll send you the three neighborhoods that put it closest.

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I'm Jeff Reynolds

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